

DAVID MULLIN

Mullin Rewrites His Littlestone Best

An 85 assembled from one triple bogey, one double at the 17th and a great many stubborn pars, and the only round on the day to better its author's TEG 13 effort at the same holes.

David Mullin's second round at Littlestone was worth 41 points and 85 gross. It was a course best by seven shots on only his second visit. His previous best there was 92.

For the first half of the front nine it looked like nothing of the sort. He took a triple bogey seven at the 4th, one of the hardest holes on the course, and got nothing for it. He followed that with a double bogey at the 5th and a bogey at the 6th. The round was being taken apart politely, hole by hole, in the correct order. Then a birdie four at the par-5 7th brought four points back. A par at the 8th kept the gross scoring clean through that stretch.

The middle of the round was solid rather than spectacular. There were pars at the 10th, the hardest hole here, worth four points, and at the 11th. Then pars at the 13th and 14th. None of it was thrilling. Thrilling was not required. Bogeys at the 15th and 16th and a double bogey at the 17th undid some of the good work, before a closing birdie four at the last restored the impression of a man in control.

The 41 points was the best score in the field. It stretched his lead in the 2021 TEG Trophy from three to nine, and in the 2021 Green Jacket from five to twelve.

AT A GLANCE

ROUND OF THE DAY

David MULLIN (41 pts)

TROPHY LEAD

David MULLIN, 9 ahead

GREEN JACKET LEAD

David MULLIN, 12 ahead

ROUND STABLEFORD

DM 41 | AB 35 | JB 29 | GW 27

ROUND GROSS

DM +14 | JB +21 | GW +26 | AB +29

AFTER R2 • TROPHY

DM 81 | AB 72 | GW 60 | JB 58

AFTER R2 • GREEN JACKET

DM +29 | JB +41 | GW +47 | AB +55

TROPHY

Three Becomes Nine at Littlestone

Alex Baker was the second-best player on the course for the second day running and went backwards in the TEG 14 Trophy anyway, while at the other end Jon Baker hauled himself to within two of Gregg Williams in the TEG 14 Wooden Spoon.

Alex Baker's second round at Littlestone came apart inside four holes. From the 2nd through the 5th he dropped 12 shots to par. A triple bogey, then a double bogey, then another triple at the 4th, one of the hardest holes on the course. Then the 9 at the 5th, a quadruple bogey on one of the easiest. Four holes without a net par. Three

Stableford points collected where eight were on offer.

That stretch accounts for the movement in the TEG 14 Trophy. Alex Baker had trailed David Mullin by three points after Royal Cinque Ports. He trails by nine now. Mullin did his part, going round in 85, his best score at Littlestone by seven shots on his only previous visit here.

At the other end of the table, the TEG 14 Wooden Spoon is closer than it was. Jon Baker is still the man holding it. His cushion over Gregg Williams has come down from four points to two. He has two rounds left to give it away, and on current evidence he is capable of it.

LITTLESTONE

The Links Collects Its Debts

Jon Baker's 79 here in TEG 13 now looks like someone else's round entirely, and Alex Baker's identical 100 was reached by a distinctly more scenic path.

Littlestone, on its second TEG visit after TEG 13, gave the field very little back. The best gross round of the day came in at 14 over par. The worst came in at 29. The Trophy returns ranged only from 41 points down to 27.

Jon Baker had set the mark on the Championship Links in TEG 13 with a 79. On Friday he signed for

92. That is thirteen strokes worse than his first visit, achieved on the same links he had previously mastered. His most productive passage of the afternoon was two pars, at the 14th and 15th, the latter one of the easiest holes on the course. Two holes without dropping a gross shot was, on this day, a good stretch.

Alex Baker matched his TEG 13 figure of 100 exactly. He arrived there via a pair of quadruple bogeys: a 9 at the 5th, one of the easiest holes on the course, and an 8 at the 8th. Reproducing a round of 100 by an entirely different route is a kind of craftsmanship. Neither Baker made the slightest impression on David Mullin, whose TEG 14 Trophy lead grew from three points to nine.

RECORDS & PERSONAL BESTS

Notable achievements: TEG 14, Round 2

COURSE RECORDS

— Alex Baker's 100 at Littlestone — equals the course-worst, his own mark from TEG 13; 5 earlier rounds there